

The Work of Winning

After Spain's World Cup victory, a case for celebrating without clutching

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“To celebrate without demanding that the feeling last forever.”

On a July afternoon in East Rutherford, the last act of the World Cup arrived in the plainest possible form: a ball over a line, a final whistle, and one set of players falling into each other while another stood with a loss too large for language. Spain beat Argentina 1-0 after extra time. A day later, in Madrid, the champions passed through an estimated crowd of almost two million people. There was a trophy, a parade, the old civic machinery of joy. And there was, beneath it, a more private spectacle: the difficult work of receiving an ending.

Sport makes endings visible. It gives them a clock, a scoreboard, a replay from three angles. Ordinary life is less obliging. A promotion arrives without a stadium; a relationship ends without a referee; a child leaves home and nobody announces the minute. Yet the emotional problem is the same. We want what is precious to stay open, even when its meaning depends on its having been brought to a close.

That is the tension hidden inside a victory. Winning feels like possession: we say we have the title, have the moment, have made history. But no one owns a moment. Not the player who scored, not the supporter who traveled, not even the nation that waves the flag. The instant it is celebrated, it has already entered memory, where it belongs partly to strangers and partly to time.

The Stoic philosopher Epictetus offers a bracing correction to the habit of possession. What matters, he argued, is not the world arranged to our liking, but our use of what arrives. This can sound chilly when read as a slogan. In practice it is an invitation to tenderness without clutching. We are allowed to care fiercely about the match, the job, the person, the hoped-for result. We are simply asked not to mistake care for control.

Spain's win is a useful little theater for this. The final was the 104th match of an expanded tournament played across three countries. Its scale was designed to make the occasion feel historic, and it did. Still, the trophy will be stored. The banners will fade. Players will wake to training schedules, injuries, family messages, decisions about the next season. The world will move on with what can seem like indecent speed. That movement is not a betrayal of the joy. It is the condition that keeps joy from becoming a museum piece.

We meet the same fact in smaller rooms. The presentation goes well, and the temptation is to read it as a permanent verdict on our ability. It goes badly, and we grant it the same false authority. A partner says something loving; a friend disappoints us; the house is full for one holiday dinner and quiet after it. The mind immediately tries to turn a passing scene into a reliable forecast. Epictetus would ask us to do something more demanding: notice what is actually ours to carry forward. Preparation, honesty, repair, gratitude, the next good action.

There is a practical discipline here. When something goes wonderfully, give it a complete welcome before turning it into an identity. Name the people who helped. Let the body register relief. Take a photograph if you like. Then ask: what does this moment invite me to practice tomorrow? When something is lost, make room for grief without rushing to convert it into a lesson. Then ask the same question. The answer may be modest: call someone back, return to the work, eat, sleep, begin again.

The parade in Madrid was not wrong to be enormous. Public celebration is one way a society tells people that excellence, effort, and shared attention still matter. But the more durable achievement may be quieter: to celebrate without demanding that the feeling last forever; to lose without believing that the self has disappeared with the result. A final whistle ends a game. It does not settle the value of a life.

The work of winning, then, is not to preserve the trophy inside us. It is to become a little more capable of meeting the next ordinary hour. When the crowd has gone home and the noise has thinned, what would it mean to treat this moment not as something you must keep, but as something that has already taught you how to let go?

SOURCES Associated Press, *The Latest: Spain scores in extra time, beats Argentina 1-0 to win World Cup* (Jul. 19, 2026), apnews.com/article/4a3a8c93c0b21c1db866f7bd857f1c32; Associated Press, *Spain's World Cup champions return home for royal welcome and parade in front of almost 2 million* (Jul. 20, 2026), apnews.com/article/cd1705a614f6ffd79da5e217f63faaaa; FIFA, *FIFA World Cup 2026 final: All you need to know* (Jul. 15, 2026), fifa.com/en/articles/final-live-watch-teams-tickets.